

Nature of Religious Language — Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

CHAPTER OVERVIEW + SOURCE MAP

How to use this companion

Syllabus scope: Philosophy of Religion. This companion visually consolidates every substantive teaching point in the learner-v2 Basic session, the complete Optional Advanced block and the consolidated register notes. Verified PYQs and original practice are retained as demand routes and answer spines; full solved-practice prose is intentionally not duplicated.

RELIGIOUS LANGUAGE: TWO INDEPENDENT AXES

HOW DOES IT MEAN?

- UNIVOCAL same concept; anthropomorphism risk
- ANALOGICAL ordered proportion; indeterminacy risk
- SYMBOLIC participation; vague-referent risk
- NEGATIVE removes limits; vacuity risk
- INDICATIVE laksana; indirect disclosure

IS IT TRUTH-APT?

- COGNITIVE asserts reality; true or false
- SYMBOLIC REALISM high non-literal mode
- MIXED SPEECH-ACT commits + expresses
- MORAL-CONATIVE second way of life
- HOSTILE NON-COGNITIVE incoherent and meaningless

Analogy and symbol answer HOW; cognitivism answers WHETHER.
A religious utterance can be assertoric, symbolic and performative at once.

STAGE 1	Separate the HOW and WHETHER axes
STAGE 2	Solve the univocal–equivocal dilemma
STAGE 3	Explain Aquinas’s analogy
STAGE 4	Explain Tillich’s participatory symbol
STAGE 5	Map the cognitivist–non-cognitivist spectrum
STAGE 6	Reconstruct verification and falsification debates
STAGE 7	Evaluate Braithwaite and Wittgensteinian use
STAGE 8	Analyse performative and self-involving language
STAGE 9	Explain symbolism as a route to mysticism
STAGE 10	Use Advaita (non-dualism)’s negation, indication and indescribability
STAGE 11	Connect semantics to religious pluralism
STAGE 12	Build 10/15/20-mark answers

Topic-specific visual gateway from the learner-v2 source.

COMPANION COVERAGE ARCHITECTURE

NO SUBSTANTIVE COMPRESSION

BASIC

75 source blocksDefinitions → core doctrines → thinkers → comparisons → traps

OPTIONAL ADVANCED

169 source blocksArguments → presuppositions → objections/replies → refinements

PYQ ROUTES

20 verified/original routesDemand decoding → named evidence → scoring spine

REGISTER NOTES

63 source blocksFinal retrieval sequence → traps → bounded verdict

UNIVERSAL PAPER-II ANSWER SPINE

Answer-writing master flow: DEFINE the contested term → STATE the central thesis → RECONSTRUCT the strongest argument with a named thinker/tradition → TEST the best objection → GIVE the reply or cost → COMPARE a rival route → END with a bounded verdict.

SOURCE DISCIPLINE

Source caution: quotation attributions, doxographic reports, cross-topic ownership notes and inference labels are preserved. A route map identifies where practice belongs; it is not a claim that an independent model answer is an official UPSC key.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

CORE DEFINITIONS + DOCTRINES + THINKERS

Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels

[FACT] identifies retained repository doctrine or verified question data. [INFERENCE] identifies learner-facing organisation or judgement.

Canonical owner §§0–7	Basic Learning Session	HOW/WHETHER map, analogy, symbol, negation, cognitivism and answer skeletons retained
Canonical owner §§9–19	Optional Advanced	Scotus, Maimonides, falsification, speech acts, mysticism, Advaita (non-dualism) and pluralism bridge retained
Audited PYQ ledger	PYQs and Answer Practice	All fourteen owner questions retained with exact wording and full solutions
Premium diagnostic set	MCQs / Remediation	Forty core and eight remedial questions retained with strict answer rotation
Original practice	PYQs and Answer Practice	Six non-PYQ solved models retained
Consolidated register	Final section	A–L retrieval framework preserves complete answer logic

Visible learning labels. Analogy, symbol, negation, cognitivist/non-cognitivist accounts, Ayer, Braithwaite, Wittgensteinian use, Tillich and Advaitic language are CORE PAPER II. Scotus, Maimonides, Flew–Hare–Mitchell, speech acts and symbol-to-mysticism are PYQ-TRIGGERED CORE. Fictionalism and specialist metaphor theory remain OPTIONAL ADVANCED.

What not to over-study. Do not merge semantic mode with truth-aptness. Analogy and symbol answer how language signifies; cognitivism asks whether it asserts truth. Do not treat Ayer, Braithwaite and Wittgenstein as one theory. Do not confuse Brahman (ultimate reality)’s ineffability with māyā (cosmic appearance and creative power)’s technical anirvacanīyatā (indefinability as either real or unreal).

Learning roadmap

1	Separate the HOW and WHETHER axes
2	Solve the univocal–equivocal dilemma
3	Explain Aquinas’s analogy
4	Explain Tillich’s participatory symbol
5	Map the cognitivist–non-cognitivist spectrum

6	Reconstruct verification and falsification debates
7	Evaluate Braithwaite and Wittgensteinian use
8	Analyse performative and self-involving language
9	Explain symbolism as a route to mysticism
10	Use Advaita (non-dualism)'s negation, indication and indescribability
11	Connect semantics to religious pluralism
12	Build 10/15/20-mark answers

Contemporary technology anchor — semantic fidelity in sacred-text translation [SUPPORTING]

CONTINUATION 1/2

[FACT] Fact: An ICML 2026 paper on Sanskrit–English translation reports that purely statistical generation can cause semantic drift in culturally embedded and ritual concepts, and proposes dictionary, morpho-syntactic and glossary-grounded decoding to preserve sacred entities and terminology. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Inference: This contemporary translation problem illustrates a core philosophical point: religious meaning is not exhausted by word substitution. Context, use, symbolic reference and a tradition’s conceptual grammar affect what an utterance means, though an AI translation benchmark does not settle whether the original claims are truth-apt. Live source checked: ICML 2026 virtual paper, “Machine

CONTINUATION 2/2

translation for civilizational knowledge systems.”

Visual gateway — never merge the two axes

HOW: univocal / analogical / symbolic / negative / indicative
WHETHER: cognitive / mixed / moral-conative / attitudinal / meaningless

Example:
"God is good" may be ANALOGICAL in semantic mode
and COGNITIVE in truth-status.

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

Master verdict: Religious utterances are often assertoric, symbolic and performative together; a mixed account preserves realist intent while acknowledging that transcendence requires non-literal modes of predication.

0. ONE-SCREEN MAP [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

PROBLEM: literal language fits finite things; God is infinite/transcendent

HOW do we speak of God? —

NEITHER literal NOR meaningless → VIA MEDIA:

- ANALOGY (Aquinas) – words apply proportionally (God is "good" analogically, not univocally/ equivocally)
- SYMBOL (Tillich) – symbols participate in the reality they point to; "God" is not a being but Being-Itself
- NEGATION (via negativa / neti neti (not this, not this)) speech (avācya (indescribable), neti neti (not this, not this)); *anirvacanīya (indefinable as either real or unreal)*

DOES it state FACTS? —

COGNITIVIST

"God exists" is a truth-claim, true or false (realism)

(Aquinas, Hick)

NON-COGNITIVIST

religious statements express attitudes/ intentions, NOT facts

Braithwaite (moral intent), Wittgenstein (form of life), Hare (blinks), Ayer (meaningless)

INDIAN: Brahman (ultimate reality) is beyond objectifying

speech (avācya (indescribable), neti neti (not this, not this)); *anirvacanīya (indefinable as either real or unreal)*

is the status of MĀYĀ (cosmic appearance and creative power) (sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa (different from both real and unreal))

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

[MNEMONIC] Mnemonic — two axes: "HOW (Analogy/Symbol/Negation) × WHETHER (Cognitive/Non-cognitive)." Analogy & symbol rescue meaning; the cog/non-cog debate is about factual truth.

1. THE PROBLEM [FACT]

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition): Religious language is discourse about transcendent reality whose central problem is how finite human concepts can be meaningful without reducing their object to finite categories.

- Univocal language (same sense as for creatures) makes God finite/anthropomorphic; equivocal language (wholly different sense) makes God-talk meaningless/unknowable. Need a middle way. [FACT]



- The Logical Positivist attack (Ayer): "God exists" is unverifiable → literally meaningless (see Paper-I Logical Positivism). This forced the whole 20th-c debate. [FACT]

2. HOW WE SPEAK — Analogy, Symbol, Negation [FACT]

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Analogy preserves ordered similarity, symbol mediates participation and negation removes creaturely limitation; each seeks meaningful reference without literal anthropomorphism.

- Analogy of attribution — "God is good" because God is the cause/source of goodness in creatures.

- (b) Symbol (Tillich — 2023, 2025 PYQ): [FACT]

- [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Tillich caution (preserve this; do not simplify it). Tillich holds that the statement "God is being-itself" is the one non-symbolic statement about God — but he modified this position in later work, and the status of the exception is disputed among his interpreters. Present it as Tillich's contested exception, note that a wholly symbolic theology faces a self-reference problem (the claim that all God-talk is symbolic is itself a claim about God), and do not report the exception as an untroubled doctrine.

- (c) Via negativa / neti neti (not this, not this): speak of God only by negation (God is not finite, not this, not that) — strong in Advaita (non-dualism) and Christian mysticism (Pseudo-Dionysius). [FACT]

- (a) Analogy (Aquinas — 2024 PYQ): religious language is analogical — between univocal and equivocal. Two types: [FACT]

- Analogy of proportionality — goodness is to God as (proportionate to His infinite nature) goodness is to a human. So "good" applies proportionally, truly but not identically. → preserves meaning without anthropomorphism.

- Religious language is symbolic, not literal. A symbol (unlike a mere sign) participates in the reality it points to and "opens up levels of reality otherwise closed". "God" is not a being among beings but the "Ground of Being" / Being-Itself; to take symbols literally is idolatry.

- Critique: if all is symbolic, what does the symbol refer to? risk of vagueness — and, correspondingly, Tillich's category of the demonic for a finite bearer that claims ultimacy for itself.

CONTINUATION 1/3

- (d) Indian — anirvacanīyatā (indefinability as either real or unreal) (2025 PYQ): [FACT] [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Fix the two uses before writing anything else. In Advaita (non-dualism), Brahman (ultimate reality) is beyond objectifying speech — avācya (indescribable), "yato vāco nivartante (from which words return)" ("whence words turn back", Taittirīya 2.9) — approached by the neti neti (not this, not this) method (Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6) and by lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning). Anirvacanīya (indefinable as either real or unreal) ("indeterminable") is the technical status of māyā (cosmic appearance and creative power)/avidyā (ignorance) and the world-appearance:

CONTINUATION 2/3

sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa (different from both real and unreal), different from both the real and the unreal, and therefore unclassifiable — which is a claim about ontological category, not about ineffability. Brahman (ultimate reality) is not indeterminable in that sense: it is sat (being or reality). The 2025 stem asks about anirvacanīyatā (indefinability as either real or unreal) in the context of the nature of religious language, so the answer must present it as a thesis about predication: ordinary language classifies, and what cannot be classified as either real or unreal defeats classificatory speech; Brahman (ultimate reality), being non-objectifiable, defeats

CONTINUATION 3/3

objectifying speech. Language therefore works eliminatively (neti neti (not this, not this)) and indicatively (lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning)), never descriptively — and is itself sublated once it has removed the error. Standard spelling: anirvacanīya (indefinable as either real or unreal) / anirvacanīyatā (indefinability as either real or unreal). Full treatment at §9.5.

3. WHETHER IT STATES FACTS — Cognitive vs Non-cognitive [FACT]

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Cognitivism treats religious claims as truth-apt, whereas non-cognitivism emphasises attitude, commitment or use; these are semantic functions, not automatically exclusive categories.

- Non-cognitivist: religious statements do not state facts; they express something else: [FACT]

- Wittgenstein / Wittgensteinian (2023 PYQ): religious language is a distinct "language-game" embedded in a form of life; its meaning is its use in worship/practice, not fact-stating; "belief in the Last Judgement" regulates a life, it's not a prediction. [FACT]

- Ayer (Logical Positivism): non-cognitive because meaningless (unverifiable) — the hostile version.

- Cognitivist (realist): religious statements are genuine truth-claims — "God exists" is true or false, asserting a fact about reality (Aquinas, Hick, Swinburne). [FACT]

- R.B. Braithwaite (2024 PYQ): religious assertions are declarations of a moral intention / commitment to a way of life (+ associated stories), not factual claims. "God is love" = an intention to live agapeistically. [FACT]

- R.M. Hare — "bliks": religious beliefs are unfalsifiable "bliks" — basic, un-provable ways of seeing the world that still matter.

- "Does the cognitivist account lead to contradiction?" (2024 — Braithwaite): [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Braithwaite argues the cognitivist (factual) reading runs into the verification problem (unverifiable → meaningless), so he reduces religious language to moral-conative use to save it. Reply: the reduction loses the believer's own realist intent (they mean God really exists) — an "atheist's account of religion". [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

4. COMPARISON GRID [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

Analogy	cognitive	proportional/attribution meaning	Aquinas	how to fix the proportion?
Symbol	(cognitive-ish)	symbols participate in Being-Itself	Tillich	referent vague
Via negativa / neti neti (not this, not this)	(limits speech)	only negation/indescribability	Dionysius, Advaita (non-dualism)	risks total silence
Moral-conative	non-cognitive	expresses moral intention	Braithwaite	loses realist meaning
Language-game	non-cognitive	use in a form of life	Wittgenstein	fideism/relativism
Verificationism	non-cog (hostile)	meaningless	Ayer	self-refuting principle

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

[MNEMONIC] The strong answer: religious language is neither literal nor meaningless — analogy/symbol give it cognitive meaning (realist), while non-cognitivists (Braithwaite/Wittgenstein) capture its practical/moral force but at the cost of its truth-claim; the believer's own intent is cognitivist.

5. FOUNDATIONAL STATEMENT BANK [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

1. [FACT] Aquinas locates God-talk between univocal sameness and equivocal disconnection through analogy.

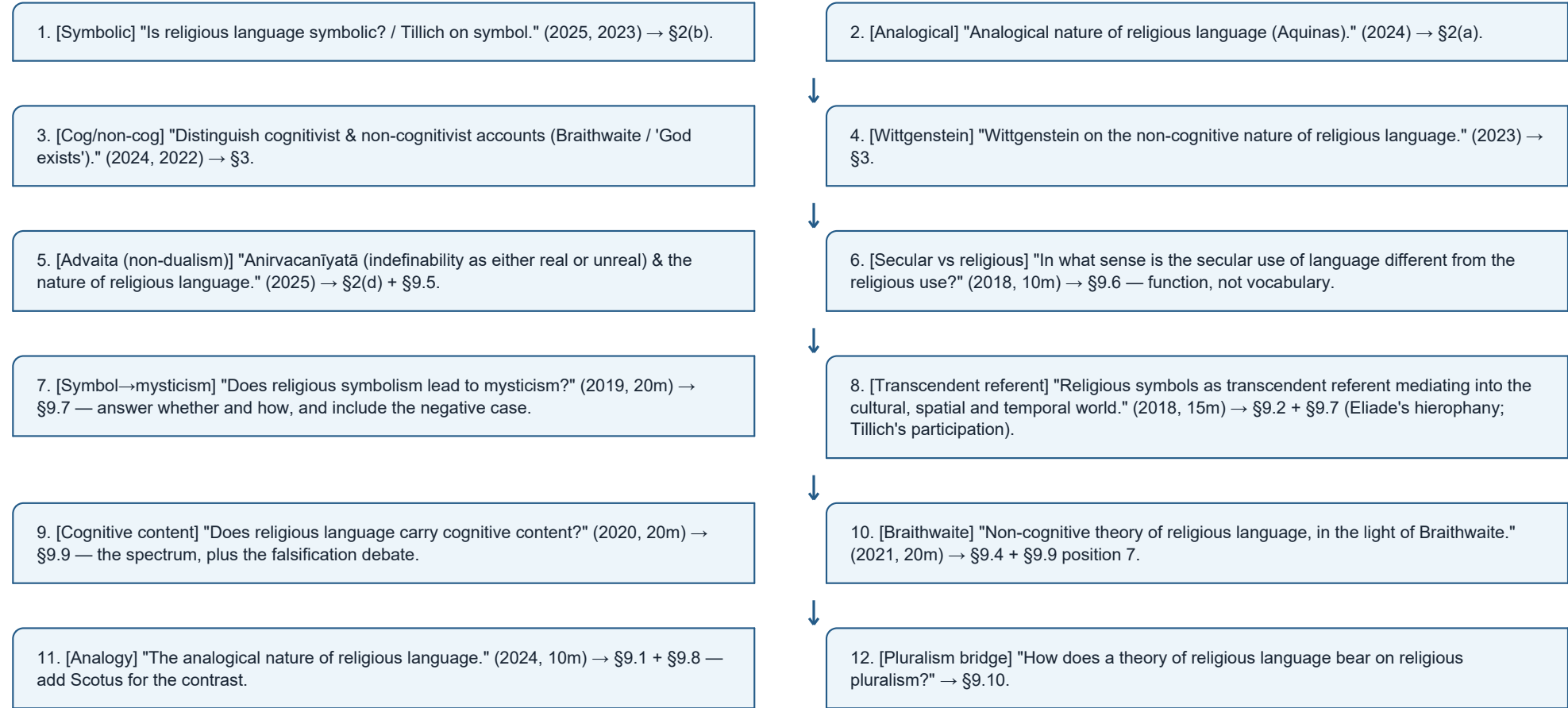
3. [FACT] Braithwaite analyses religious assertion through commitment to a moral way of life and its sustaining stories.

5. [FACT] The Upaniṣadic formula yato vāco nivartante (from which words return) marks the limit of objectifying speech; Advaita (non-dualism) also deploys neti neti (not this, not this) and indirect indication.

2. [FACT] Tillich treats religious symbols as participatory and God as being-itself rather than one being among others.

4. [FACT] Wittgensteinian approaches interpret religious meaning through use within a form of life.

6. APPLIED-QUESTION DRILLS [INFERENCE / CAUTION]



6A. PARITY BENCH — the same three exits, East and West [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A complete answer must keep two axes separate: how religious predicates refer and whether religious utterances assert facts.

Univocity (common concept, different mode/degree)	Duns Scotus	Nyāya (logic and epistemology school) — Īśvara (Lord or special spiritual self)'s knowledge and will predicated in essentially our sense	Anthropomorphism; God becomes an item in a shared order
Analogy / indirect indication	Aquinas (attribution, proportionality)	Advaita (non-dualism)'s lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning) — bhāga-tyāga in "tat tvam asi (That thou art)"	Indeterminacy: how is the proportion or the retained portion fixed?
Negation	Pseudo-Dionysius; Maimonides (negations + attributes of action)	Neti neti (not this, not this); yato vāco nivartante (from which words return)	Vacuity: unlimited negation cannot distinguish the ultimate from nothing
Symbol / participation	Tillich; Ramsey's model-and-qualifier	Pratīka (symbolic aid to meditation)/pratimā (sacred image or icon); oṃkāra (sacred syllable Om) → turīya (fourth state of consciousness)	Vague referent; risk of idolatry/arrest
Performative / injunctive	Austin, Evans (self-involving language)	Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school)'s vidhi (injunction); mantra as instrument	Does not by itself settle truth-aptness

7. PYQ-MAPPED MODEL-ANSWER SKELETONS [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

7.1 — "Distinguish cognitivist & non-cognitivist accounts; does cognitivism lead to contradiction? (Braithwaite)" (2024, 20m)

Intro : the problem – can God-talk be literal/factual? B1 : cognitivist – "God exists" is a truth-claim (Aquinas, Hick); realism. B2 : non-cognitivist – expresses attitude/intention (Braithwaite: moral intention), use in a form of life (Wittgenstein), blik (Hare), or meaningless (Ayer). Assess: cognitivism faces the verification problem → Braithwaite reduces to moral use; BUT that loses the believer's realist intent (an "atheist's account"). Concl : religious language is best read as analogical/symbolic-yet-cognitive – meaningful AND truth-apt.

7.2 — "Is religious language symbolic? (Tillich)" (2025, 10m)

Intro : literal language fails for the transcendent; Tillich's symbolic theory. Body : symbols (unlike signs) participate in what they point to; "God" = Being-Itself, not a being; literalism = idolatry; only "God is Being-Itself" is non-symbolic. Crit : referent becomes vague; compare Aquinas' analogy (more determinate). Concl : religious language is symbolic – pointing beyond itself to the Ground of Being.
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7.3 — "In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use?" (2018, 10m)

Line 1: the difference is NOT lexical – religion borrows ordinary words. It is functional.

Axes : function (describe/predict vs worship, invoke, confess, vow, bless);
 reference (empirical particulars vs a referent not available for ostension);
 verification (determinate procedures vs contested/eschatological/none);
 logic (paradox a defect vs paradox, negation, symbol and myth tolerated);
 self-involvement (detachable vs committing the speaker);
 register (any competent speaker vs tradition-formed, often a sacral register).

Tools : Austin – constative vs performative; "I baptise", "I take refuge", *saṃkalpa* (intentional resolve), vow, blessing.
 Evans – self-involving language. Ramsey – model + qualifier producing a disclosure situation.

Indian: Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school)'s *vidhi* (injunction) (the śāstra (authoritative treatise)'s primary mood is imperative, not indicative);
 mantra as instrument; śabda-nityatva (eternality of word) (NOT *sphoṭa* (indivisible burst of linguistic meaning), which is the grammarians');
 Advaita (non-dualism)'s *lakṣaṇā* (secondary or implied meaning) and *neti neti* (not this, not this) as technical non-ordinary uses.

Caution: religious language remains parasitic on ordinary language and subject to ordinary logic – it is a stretched use of a common instrument, not a separate instrument.

Concl : the difference is one of function, referent, logic and commitment, not of vocabulary.

7.4 — "Discuss whether and how religious symbolism leads to mysticism." (2019, 20m)

Intro : two obligations – WHETHER and HOW. The "how" carries the marks.

Affirmative route: (1) symbol participates and opens levels of reality (Tillich);
 (2) use draws the participant in – ecstasy, being grasped by ultimate concern;
 (3) the symbol becomes transparent and finally self-effacing;
 (4) terminus = immediacy without mediation.
 Ricoeur: "the symbol gives rise to thought"; the second *naïveté*.
 Dionysius: cataphatic → apophatic → the darkness beyond light.

Indian: *pratīka* (symbolic aid to meditation)/*pratimā* (sacred image or icon) *upāsana* (meditative worship) as graded and preparatory; *saguna* (with qualities) → *nirguna* (without qualities);
 Māṇḍūkya's *omkāra* (sacred syllable *Om*) – three *mātrās* (sound units or measures) and the soundless fourth (*turiya* (fourth state of consciousness)) as the non-symbolic culmination; tantric mantra/yantra (sacred geometric instrument) internalised and dissolved; Sufi *ishārāt*.

Negative case: symbols can ARREST – Tillich's idolatry and the demonic;
 Katz's constructivism (no unmediated experience → symbol CONSTITUTES rather than leads to);
 iconoclastic routes (Zen, *neti neti* (not this, not this)) that advance by deleting symbols;
 non-necessity – ethics, *manana* (reflective contemplation) and grace are alternative routes.

Concl : a normal but not a necessary route; it leads there only when the symbol is used as an instrument to be transcended – and on the constructivist view the relation is not sequential at all.

7.5 — "The analogical nature of religious language." (2024, 10m) — with the Scotist contrast

Intro : the dilemma – univocal predication anthropomorphises, equivocal predication silences.
Body : Aquinas' middle way – analogy of **ATTRIBUTION** (healthy: animal primarily, medicine derivatively) and analogy of **PROPORTIONALITY** (goodness to God as goodness to a creature, each according to its mode); ground = causal participation;
res significata (applies to God) vs modus significandi (creaturely).
Contrast: Scotus – unless "being" and the pure perfections are **UNIVOCAL**, inference to God equivocates; the certain/doubtful argument shows the concept of being is neutral; univocity is **SEMANTIC**, with finite/infinite intrinsic modes restoring the ontological gulf.
Exchange: Scotist charge – analogy without a univocal core is disguised equivocation;
Thomist reply – the causal relation supplies the middle term, not a shared concept.
Third pole: Maimonides – only negations and attributes of action; objection = vacuity.
Indian: Nyāya (logic and epistemology school) ≈ univocity; Advaita (non-dualism)'s lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning) ≈ analogy; neti neti (not this, not this) ≈ negation.
Concl : univocity buys inference at the risk of anthropomorphism; analogy buys transcendence at the risk of indeterminacy; negation buys purity at the risk of vacuity.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH

NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

The advanced dossier adds four bounded refinements: analogy versus metaphorical realism; verification, falsification and eschatological verification; expressivism or fictionalism versus realism; and Advaitic lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning) against the self-reference worry. These refine, rather than replace, the canonical HOW/WHETHER structure.

9. ADVANCED DOCTRINE DOSSIERS

9.1 Aquinas' analogy

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition): Aquinas' analogy asserts real but non-univocal similarity between creaturely perfections and their divine source, preserving both intelligibility and transcendence.

- Doctrine statement. [FACT] Predicates such as good and wise apply to God neither in exactly the creaturely sense nor in a wholly unrelated sense, but analogically.



- Argument. [FACT] (1) Creatures depend causally on God and display perfections; (2) effects resemble causes without matching their mode; (3) perfection terms can therefore signify truly while their mode of possession differs infinitely.

- Distinction. [FACT] Analogy of attribution relates secondary instances to a primary source; proportionality compares relations according to distinct modes of being.

- Objection → reply. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Without a univocal core, analogy is indeterminate. Thomist reply: causal relation and perfection supply ordered content, though critics ask how it can be specified without prior knowledge of God.

- Presupposition. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Causal participation warrants semantic continuity and pure perfections can be separated from creaturely limitation.

- Canonical example. [FACT] "Healthy" applies primarily to an animal and derivatively to medicine as cause/sign; divine goodness is not exactly this example but it shows ordered, non-univocal predication.



9.2 Tillich's symbol

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: For Tillich, a religious symbol participates in the reality it discloses and opens levels of reality and self otherwise inaccessible, but it must remain distinguishable from mere emotional projection.

- Argument. [FACT] Ultimate concern exceeds literal object-language; symbols mediate participation without turning God into one being among others; "God" symbolises being-itself.

- Distinction. [FACT] A sign has conventional reference without participation; a symbol carries depth and transformative power.

- Doctrine statement. [FACT] Religious symbols point beyond themselves, participate in what they indicate, open levels of reality and self, arise collectively and can die.

- Presupposition. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Participatory reference is intelligible and symbolic mediation can retain truth.

- Canonical example. [FACT] A national flag participates in collective identity more deeply than a traffic sign; religious symbolism is stronger still.



- Objection → reply. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] If every God-statement is symbolic, reference becomes vague. Tillich retains being-itself as the non-symbolic basis, though this exception is debated.

9.3 Cognitivism, verification and falsification

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The verification and falsification debates test whether religious claims exclude any possible state of affairs; a meaningful theology must specify evidential risk without demanding laboratory verification.

- Argument. [FACT] Ayer's criterion excludes unverifiable metaphysics. Flew's gardener presses the erosion of content under endless qualification. Mitchell's partisan permits trust to survive counterevidence without becoming unfalsifiable.

- Distinction. [FACT] Verification concerns possible confirmation; falsification concerns possible disconfirmation; eschatological verification claims future confirmation without present falsifiability.

- Objection → reply. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Verification criteria may be self-undermining and too narrow. Critics replace strict empirical verification with broader realism and cumulative warrant.

- Doctrine statement. [FACT] Cognitivism treats religious assertions as truth-apt; verificationism challenges their empirical meaning; falsification asks what conceivable evidence could count against them.



- Presupposition. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Factual meaning requires specified evidential consequences, or at least vulnerability to reasons.



- Canonical example. [FACT] Hick's celestial-city parable models a claim verified at journey's end.



9.4 Braithwaite, Hare and Wittgensteinian use

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Non-cognitive theories clarify commitment and form of life, but they become reductive if they deny that believers also intend claims about reality.

- Doctrine statement. [FACT] Braithwaite interprets religious assertions as commitments to a moral policy supported by stories; Hare's blik is a basic world-picture; Wittgensteinian approaches locate meaning in a religious form of life.



- Argument. [FACT] Meaning is shown by use in worship, repentance, hope and conduct rather than by isolated correspondence tests.

- Distinction. [FACT] Non-cognitive does not mean emotionally trivial or meaningless; Ayer's hostile non-cognitivism differs from use/commitment accounts.

- Objection → reply. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Reduction to use or morality misdescribes believers who intend realist claims. Reply: non-cognitivists capture function; a mixed account may retain both truth-claim and performative force.

- Presupposition. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Practical role can constitute or explain meaning without factual description.

- Canonical examples. [FACT] Braithwaite's agapeistic policy; Hare's paranoid student; religious use of Last Judgement as life-orienting.



9.5 Advaita (non-dualism), negation and indirect indication

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Advaita (non-dualism) combines *neti neti* (not this, not this) with *lakṣaṇā* (secondary or implied meaning) to deny finite predicates while indirectly indicating Brahman (ultimate reality).

- Argument. [FACT] Words ordinarily denote qualified objects; Brahman (ultimate reality) is not such an object; negation and *lakṣaṇā* (secondary or implied meaning) remove incompatible literal senses so identity teaching can disclose the intended non-dual referent.

- Distinction. [FACT] Brahman (ultimate reality) is ineffable, while *māyā* (cosmic appearance and creative power) is often termed *anirvacanīya* (indefinable as either real or unreal) as neither absolutely real nor unreal; do not collapse the two uses.

- Objection → reply. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] If all predicates fail, teaching is self-defeating. Advaita (non-dualism) replies that language removes ignorance like a thorn removing a thorn and is itself sublated after knowledge.

- Doctrine statement. [FACT] Brahman (ultimate reality) exceeds literal predication; *neti neti* (not this, not this) removes limiting identifications, while Upaniṣadic sentences indirectly indicate non-dual reality.

- Presupposition. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Language can function eliminatively and indicatively beyond ordinary denotation.

- Canonical example. [FACT] In "That thou art," incompatible omniscient/finite connotations are set aside to indicate consciousness as the common import.



9.6 Secular versus religious use of language (2018 Q5(a) owner-module)

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious and secular language share grammar, but religious use is distinguished by its ultimate referent, self-involving force, communal practice and resistance to exhaustive literalisation.

- The right framing. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] The difference is not lexical — religious discourse borrows almost all its words from ordinary language ("father", "light", "path", "see", "hear", "know"). The difference lies in function, reference, logic and commitment. Say this in the first two lines; scripts that hunt for a special religious vocabulary go nowhere.

- Six axes of difference. [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

Primary function	Describe, predict, instruct, inform	Worship, invoke, confess, bless, vow, consecrate, commit
Reference	Empirical particulars and their relations	A transcendent referent not available for ostension
Verification	Determinate procedures; corrigible by observation	[INFERENCE / CAUTION] Contested — eschatological, experiential, or none
Logic	Paradox is a defect	Paradox, negation, symbol and myth are tolerated and sometimes required
Self-involvement	Usually detachable from the speaker	Typically self-involving: the utterance commits the speaker
Community and register	Any competent speaker	Tradition-formed; often a sacral register (mantra, liturgical Latin, Qur'ānic Arabic) with untranslatability claims

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- The speech-act analysis (the strongest single tool here). [FACT] J. L. Austin's distinction between constative and performative, and between locutionary / illocutionary / perlocutionary force, shows that many religious utterances are not descriptions that happen to be unverifiable but performatives whose success-conditions are different: "I baptise you", "I take refuge in the Buddha", "saṃkalpa (intentional resolve)" at the start of a rite, a vow, a blessing, a curse. [FACT] Donald Evans, The Logic of Self-Involvement (1963), applies this systematically: religious language is characteristically self-involving — it expresses attitudes, commits the speaker to

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conduct, and constitutes relationships. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] This does not make religious language non-cognitive: "I baptise" presupposes a whole set of assertions, and a performative can carry assertoric commitments.

- Ian Ramsey's "models and qualifiers" [FACT] (Religious Language, 1957): religious language works by taking an ordinary model ("father", "cause", "good") and applying a qualifier ("heavenly", "first", "infinitely") that stretches the model until the "penny drops" — a disclosure situation evoking discernment and commitment. This explains how ordinary words are used religiously without becoming equivocal.

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- Indian material. [FACT] Mantra is the paradigm of language whose primary function is not description: Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) treats mantras as liturgical instruments within an injunctive structure, and the school's doctrines of the eternity of the word (śabda-nityatva (eternality of word)) and the eternal word–meaning relation are advanced precisely to ground a non-conventional sacred register [INFERENCE / CAUTION] (the sphoṭa (indivisible burst of linguistic meaning) theory belongs to the grammarians and should not be attributed to Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school)). [FACT] Vedic injunctive language (vidhi (injunction)) is grammatically imperative, not indicative — the śāstra (authoritative treatise)

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(authoritative treatise)'s primary mood is "let it be done", which is a functional difference of exactly the kind this question asks about. [FACT] Advaita (non-dualism)'s lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning) (indirect indication) and neti neti (not this, not this) are technical devices for a use of language that ordinary predication cannot perform.

- The continuity thesis (do not overstate the difference). [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Religious language is parasitic on ordinary language, is learned in ordinary contexts, and remains subject to ordinary logic. The best conclusion is that it is a stretched and re-purposed use of a common instrument, not a separate instrument.

- Verdict formula. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] "Secular and religious uses of language differ in function, referent, logic and self-involvement, not in vocabulary. Religious language stretches ordinary words by model-and-qualifier, and its characteristic utterances are performative and self-involving as well as assertoric — which is why criteria designed for descriptive discourse alone will always misjudge it."

9.7 Does religious symbolism lead to mysticism? (2019 Q6(a) owner-module)

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Symbolism can lead toward mysticism by mediating participation and then yielding to direct experience, but no symbol logically guarantees a mystical encounter.

- The exact question. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Two obligations: whether it does, and how it does. Both must be answered, and the "how" is where the marks are.

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- The affirmative route, in four steps. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] (1) A symbol (unlike a sign) participates in what it signifies and "opens up levels of reality otherwise closed" (Tillich). (2) In use, the symbol therefore does not merely inform but draws the participant into the reality it mediates — Tillich's language of ecstasy, being grasped by ultimate concern. (3) As participation deepens, the symbol's mediating role becomes transparent and finally self-effacing: what was a pointer becomes a window and then disappears. (4) The terminus of that trajectory is immediacy without mediation — mysticism. [FACT] Paul Ricoeur supplies the classic formula for the intellectual side of this

- The Western structural support. [FACT] The cataphatic → apophatic movement in Pseudo-Dionysius: affirmative theology names God from creatures, negative theology strips the names away, and the ascent culminates in a "darkness beyond light" and silence — an explicit doctrine that symbolic affirmation is the road to mystical unknowing. [FACT] Eliade's hierophany makes the same point sociologically: the sacred is only ever encountered through something, and the encounter can deepen past its vehicle.

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(sound units or measures) correspond to waking, dream and deep sleep, with the soundless fourth (amātra (measureless soundless fourth), turiya (fourth state of consciousness)) as the non-symbolic culmination — the single most exact textual instance of a symbol leading beyond itself. [FACT] Tantric mantra, yantra (sacred geometric instrument) and maṇḍala (sacred geometric diagram) are explicitly constructed as instrumental symbols to be internalised and dissolved. [FACT] Sufi ishārāt (allusive signs) function similarly in the Islamic tradition.

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movement: "the symbol gives rise to thought" (The Symbolism of Evil), with his "second naïveté" describing a post-critical re-inhabiting of symbol.

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- The Indian route (stronger and more systematic — use it). [FACT] Pratīka (symbolic aid to meditation) and pratimā (sacred image or icon) upāsana (meditative worship): meditation on a symbol or image is an authorised, graded sādhanā, and the tradition explicitly ranks it below, and as preparatory to, direct realisation. [FACT] Saṅgā (with qualities) → nirguṇa (without qualities): worship of the qualified is preparatory to the realisation of the unqualified — the entire Advaitic pedagogy is the trajectory the question asks about. [FACT] Omkāra (sacred syllable Om): the Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad (philosophical Vedic text) treats OM as a symbol whose three mātṛās (sound units or measures)

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- The negative case (a top-band answer must include it). [INFERENCE / CAUTION] (1) Arrest and idolatry: symbols can stop the journey rather than advance it — Tillich's own warning that a symbol taken literally becomes idolatrous, and his category of the demonic for a finite bearer claiming ultimacy. (2) Constructivist objection (Katz): if there are no unmediated experiences, mysticism is always symbol-shaped and never escapes symbol at all — so symbolism does not "lead to" mysticism, it constitutes it. (3) Empirical objection: some mystics report the collapse of images without prior symbolic practice, and some traditions (Zen's iconoclasm, neti neti (not this, not this)) advance

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by deleting symbols rather than deepening them. (4) Non-necessity: even where symbols help, they are one route; ethical practice, dialectical inquiry (manana (reflective contemplation)) and grace are others.

- Verdict formula. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] "Religious symbolism is a normal but not a necessary route to mysticism. It leads there when it is used as an instrument to be transcended — *pratīka* (symbolic aid to meditation) to *nirguṇa* (without qualities), cataphatic to apophatic, *omkāra* (sacred syllable Om) to *tūrīya* (fourth state of consciousness); it obstructs when it is taken literally, which is precisely Tillich's charge of idolatry. And on the constructivist view the relation is not sequential at all: symbol does not lead to mysticism, it shapes it from the start."

9.8 Aquinas' analogy against Scotus' univocity (and Maimonides' negation)**KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC**

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Scotus demands a minimal univocal concept for valid inference, while Aquinas insists that causal participation secures continuity without placing God and creatures in one genus.

- The problem the three answer. [FACT] If "good" said of God means exactly what it means of creatures (univocal), God is finite and anthropomorphic. If it means something wholly different (equivocal), we say nothing at all — and every argument to God commits the fallacy of equivocation. The three classical exits are analogy, univocity of concept, and negation.

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- Aquinas: analogy. [FACT] Predicates apply to God and creatures neither univocally nor equivocally but analogically, by an ordered proportion. Two forms: analogy of attribution (a term applies primarily to one thing and derivatively to others by relation to it — "healthy" of an animal primarily, of medicine and complexion derivatively) and analogy of proportionality (goodness is to God as goodness is to a creature, each according to its own mode of being). The metaphysical ground is causal participation: effects resemble their cause without matching its mode; so perfection-terms signify truly of God while the mode of possession differs infinitely

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(*res significata* vs *modus significandi* — the thing signified applies to God, the manner of signifying is creaturely).

- Scotus: univocity of the concept of being. [FACT] Duns Scotus argues that unless "being" and the pure perfections are predicated univocally of God and creatures, natural knowledge of God is impossible and every inference from creatures to God equivocates.

- His argument from certain and doubtful concepts: one can be certain that God is a being while remaining doubtful whether God is finite or infinite. A concept about which one is certain cannot be the same concept as one about which one is doubtful; therefore the concept "being" is neutral between finite and infinite — hence univocal.

- [INFERENCE / CAUTION] The crucial qualification that most scripts miss: Scotus' univocity is semantic/conceptual, not ontological. He does not say God and creatures are beings in the same way; he says the concept must be common if our reasoning is to be valid. The real difference is then reintroduced by the intrinsic modes finite/infinite — so univocity of concept is fully compatible with an infinite ontological gulf, and the charge of anthropomorphism is not automatic.

- Scotist objection to analogy: an analogy without any univocal core collapses into equivocation — if the concept applied to God shares nothing with the concept applied to creatures, no inference can pass between them, and "analogy" is just a name for a gap.

- Thomist objection to univocity: a common concept of being flattens the Creator–creature distinction and makes God an item within a shared category. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Some later critics (Heidegger on onto-theology; and, more contentiously, the Radical Orthodoxy readings of Milbank and Pickstock [SOURCE CAUTION] — a contested historical thesis) trace modern secular metaphysics to this move. Cite the thesis as contested.

- Maimonides: the negative way. [FACT] Guide for the Perplexed I.50–60 holds that no positive essential attribute may be affirmed of God; permissible speech is confined to negations (God is not ignorant, not powerless) and attributes of action (God is called merciful from what God does, not from a quality God possesses). [INFERENCE / CAUTION] The standing objection is that unlimited negation yields silence and cannot distinguish God from nothing — precisely the objection Advaita (non-dualism) also faces.

- The exchange (this is the examinable core). [INFERENCE / CAUTION]

- Thomist reply: the ordered causal relation supplies the content that univocity would have supplied, without importing the creaturely mode; the middle term of the inference is the causal dependence, not a shared concept.

- Scotist reply: God is not placed in a genus; "being" is not a genus, and the intrinsic mode of infinity preserves the distinction.

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- Indian parity (exact, not decorative). [FACT] Advaita (non-dualism)'s lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning) is the structural analogue of analogy: in "tat tvam asi (That thou art)" the jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā (implication by partial abandonment and retention) (also called bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā (implication by partial rejection and retention)) discards the incompatible portions of both terms (the omniscience of tat, the finitude of tvam) and retains the common import, pure consciousness — a use of language that is neither literal nor arbitrary. [FACT] Neti neti (not this, not this) is the Indian via negativa, matching Maimonides. [FACT] Nyāya (logic and epistemology school)

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is the closest Indian analogue of univocity: Īśvara (Lord or special spiritual self)'s knowledge, will and agency are predicated in essentially the same sense as ours, differing in degree and scope, and Nyāya (logic and epistemology school) accepts the consequence that God is a self (ātman (self)) among selves, distinguished by eternality and omniscience. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] So the Western three-way debate has a genuine Indian counterpart: Nyāya (logic and epistemology school) ≈ univocity, Advaita (non-dualism)'s lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning) ≈ analogy, neti neti (not this, not this) ≈ negation — and each faces the same objection as its Western twin.

- Verdict formula. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] "The three positions trade the same currency. Univocity secures inference and risks anthropomorphism; analogy secures transcendence and risks indeterminacy; negation secures purity and risks vacuity. Since a defensible theology needs all three goods, the workable position is analogical predication with a univocal minimum for the terms used in argument and an apophatic limit on their adequacy."

9.9 The cognitivist–non-cognitivist spectrum (not a binary)

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious utterances may simultaneously assert, evaluate, commit and perform; the best account is therefore a disciplined spectrum rather than a binary.

- [INFERENCE / CAUTION] The commonest structural error in this clause is treating cognitivism/non-cognitivism as two boxes. It is a spectrum of positions about truth-aptness and mode of reference, and placing thinkers on it correctly is what separates bands.

1	Strong literal realism	[FACT] Fully	Some predicates apply to God literally, though not univocally in every respect	William Alston, Divine Nature and Human Language; Swinburne (ordinary words with stretched senses)
2	Analogical realism	[FACT] Yes	Analogy of attribution/proportionality	Aquinas
3	Symbolic realism	[INFERENCE / CAUTION] Yes, but symbolically	Participation; model-and-qualifier	Tillich; Ian Ramsey
4	Eschatologically verified realism	[FACT] Yes	Truth-apt now, confirmable later	Hick (celestial-city parable)
5	Mixed speech-act views	[FACT] In part	Assertion plus commissive/expressive force	Donald Evans; Alston's speech-act analysis
6	Wittgensteinian "meaning is use"	[INFERENCE / CAUTION] Contested	Grammar internal to a form of life	D. Z. Phillips [SOURCE CAUTION] — he denied being a non-cognitivist or reductionist, insisting he described religious grammar rather than reducing it; report the dispute, do not assert the label
7	Moral-conative reduction	? Not primarily	Declaration of a moral policy + sustaining stories	R. B. Braithwaite
8	Attitudinal/blik	? Not fact-stating	Unfalsifiable basic world-picture	R. M. Hare
9	Non-realism / fictionalism	? Not asserted	Practice retained without assertion	Don Cupitt; Robin Le Poidevin

10	Hostile non-cognitivism	? Meaningless	Verification criterion	A. J. Ayer

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- The falsification debate that produced positions 7–8. [FACT] The 1950–51 "Theology and Falsification" exchange: Antony Flew adapts John Wisdom's parable of the invisible gardener — a claim qualified until nothing could count against it "dies the death of a thousand qualifications" — and asks the believer what would have to occur for them to concede that God does not exist or does not love us. R. M. Hare replies with bliks (the paranoid student convinced all dons want to murder him — unfalsifiable, but not therefore unimportant). Basil Mitchell replies with the partisan and the Stranger: the partisan's trust survives apparently contrary evidence without becoming

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vacuous, because he acknowledges the evidence counts against him. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Mitchell's is the position most defenders of cognitivism take: religious claims are defeasible but not decisively falsifiable in this life. [FACT] Hick's eschatological verification answers Flew from the other side — the claim is verifiable in principle, just not now.

- The two standing objections, symmetrical. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Against cognitivism: the verification/falsification pressure, and the difficulty of specifying the referent. Against non-cognitivism: reductionism — it misdescribes believers, who intend to assert something, and it cannot explain why anyone would adopt the moral policy if the stories are known to be false (Braithwaite's account has been called "an atheist's account of religion" for exactly this reason).

- Verdict formula. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] "The cognitive/non-cognitive question is badly put as a binary. Religious utterances are typically assertoric, symbolic and performative at once; the defensible position is a mixed speech-act account that preserves the believer's realist intent (against Braithwaite) while acknowledging that the assertions are analogical or symbolic in mode (against crude literalism) and defeasible rather than decisively falsifiable (with Mitchell)."

9.10 The pluralism bridge: how a theory of religious language decides the pluralism question

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A theory of religious language determines the scope of pluralism: literal contradiction narrows it, while analogical or symbolic mediation permits diversity without automatic relativism. [FACT] Bidirectional cross-link: Religious Pluralism §9.11 and §19.

- The thesis. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Positions on religious pluralism are downstream of positions on religious language. The route runs: semantics → epistemic access → the status of rival descriptions → exclusivism or pluralism.

- The two branches.

- If God-talk is univocal and literal: the descriptions of different traditions are directly commensurable, so where they conflict, at most one is true. "God is a personal creator" and "there is no personal creator" are then flat contradictories, and exclusivism follows naturally; the pluralist must either deny one claim or abandon the literalism.

- If God-talk is analogical, symbolic or apophatic: no finite formulation exhausts its referent; different traditions' descriptions may then be partial, mode-relative and non-competing modes of reference to one reality — and pluralism becomes intelligible without relativism.

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- Hick's pluralism is a religious-language thesis. [FACT] This is the point that earns the marks. Hick's claim that the Real an sich is transcategorical — that none of our substantial concepts (personal/impersonal, one/many, good, purposive) applies to it literally — is a claim about the limits of predication, not primarily about religions. His personae and impersonae of the Real (Yahweh, Kṛṣṇa, Allah, Brahman (ultimate reality), Śūnyatā) are the phenomenal terms under which the transcategorical Real is humanly experienced. Hence: remove the semantic thesis and the pluralist hypothesis collapses; and the standard objection to Hick — that an entity of which nothing



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substantial can be said is indistinguishable from nothing, and cannot ground worship or discriminate between traditions — is likewise a semantic objection, the same one Maimonides' negative theology faces.

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- The Indian resources for the same bridge. [FACT] (1) Advaita (non-dualism)'s two-level semantics: nirguṇa (without qualities) Brahman (ultimate reality) is beyond exhaustive predication while saguṇa (with qualities) forms structure real devotional paths — a built-in apparatus for holding one ultimate together with many valid descriptions, and the metaphysical ground of Vivekananda's pluralism. (2) Jain anekāntavāda (doctrine of many-sided reality)/syādvāda (doctrine of conditioned predication) does the same work as a logic rather than a metaphysics: saptabhaṅgī (sevenfold predication) prefixes each assertion with syāt (in some respect) ("in a certain respect"), marking



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standpoint-relativity inside the proposition, so that apparently contradictory religious claims can be located on different nayas (partial standpoints) without either being simply false. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] This is more disciplined than Hick, because it specifies the respect rather than retreating to unknowability. (3) RV 1.164.46's distinction between one referent and many names is precisely a semantic distinction — which is why the attribution discipline in the Pluralism file matters here too.

- The limit — state it, or the answer over-claims. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Non-literal semantics dissolves some apparent conflicts (personal vs impersonal description of the ultimate) and cannot dissolve others. Existence-claims are not mode-relative: either there is post-mortem individual survival or there is not; either there is a creator or there is not. A semantic pluralism that pretends to dissolve those is evasion, and the honest position routes hard contradictions rather than harmonising them.



- Verdict formula. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] "How one speaks about God determines how many traditions one can regard as speaking about God. Univocal literalism makes rival descriptions contradictory and pushes toward exclusivism; analogical, symbolic and apophatic semantics makes them partial and mode-relative, and makes pluralism intelligible. Hick's Real is the clearest case that a pluralist hypothesis is really a thesis about the limits of predication — and it inherits, in full, the vacuity objection that every apophatic theology faces."

10. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Compare theories by asking what secures reference, what protects transcendence, what truth-status remains and what would count as misuse or failure.

Aquinas	[FACT] Yes	Analogy/causal participation	Realism without crude anthropomorphism	Indeterminacy
Tillich	[INFERENCE / CAUTION] Symbolically realist	Participation	Depth and transformation	Vague referent
Ayer	? No factual meaning	Verification criterion	Evidential discipline	Criterion too narrow/self-problem
Braithwaite	? Not primarily factual	Moral intention and story	Captures practice	Reductionism
Wittgensteinian	[INFERENCE / CAUTION] Meaning in use	Language-game/form of life	Context sensitivity	Fideism/insulation
Advaita (non-dualism)	[FACT] Indicative, non-literal	Negation and lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning)	Avoids objectifying Brahman (ultimate reality)	Self-reference/silence
Scotus	[FACT] Yes	Univocal concept + intrinsic modes finite/infinite	Secures the validity of inference to God	Alleged onto-theology [SOURCE CAUTION]
Maimonides	[INFERENCE / CAUTION] Only negations and attributes of action	Via negativa	Protects divine transcendence	Vacuity — cannot distinguish God from nothing
Nyāya (logic and epistemology school)	[FACT] Yes	Near-univocal predication of Īśvara (Lord or special spiritual self)'s knowledge/will	Determinate, argument-friendly	Anthropomorphism; God as one ātman (self) among selves
Mitchell	[FACT] Yes	Defeasible trust that concedes counterevidence	Answers Flew without vacuity	Boundary with unfalsifiability is fine
Hick	[FACT] Yes	Eschatological verification; transcategorical Real	Bridges to pluralism	The Real risks emptiness

11. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Every theory pays a semantic price: univocity risks anthropomorphism, equivocity destroys inference, analogy risks vagueness and symbolism risks non-cognitive reduction.

2. Agnosticism. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] If senses differ too much, nothing is said. Reply: causal relation, practice and negation constrain meaning.

4. Reductionism. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Non-cognitivism ignores intended realism. Reply: mixed speech-act accounts distinguish assertion, commitment, prayer and expression.

1. Anthropomorphism. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Literal divine predicates project human traits. Reply: analogy/symbol changes mode while retaining ordered content.

3. Fideism. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Language-game accounts immunise belief. Reply: internal grammar need not exclude external moral and epistemic criticism.

5. Advaitic self-reference. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Saying "Brahman (ultimate reality) is indescribable" describes it. Reply: the statement limits objectifying discourse rather than predicates an ordinary property.

12. COMMON UPSC TRAPS

1. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not equate analogical with metaphorical.

3. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not group Ayer, Braithwaite and Wittgenstein as holding the same non-cognitivism.

5. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not attribute every language-game reading directly to explicit doctrines of Wittgenstein without noting the Wittgensteinian development.

7. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not answer "secular vs religious language" by hunting for special words. The difference is function, referent, logic and self-involvement — use Austin's performatives, Evans' self-involvement and Ramsey's model-and-qualifier.

2. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not say a Tillichian symbol is a mere sign.

4. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not infer that non-cognitive means insignificant.

6. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not say Brahman (ultimate reality) and māyā (cosmic appearance and creative power) are indescribable in exactly the same sense.

8. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not attribute the sphoṭa (indivisible burst of linguistic meaning) theory to Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school). Śabda-nityatva (eternality of word) and the eternal word–meaning relation are Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school); sphoṭa (indivisible burst of linguistic meaning) belongs to the grammarians (Bhartṛhari).

9. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not say symbolism necessarily leads to mysticism. It is a normal but non-necessary route; symbols can also arrest in literalism (Tillich's idolatry/demonic), and on Katz's constructivism symbol constitutes rather than leads to mystical experience.

11. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not present the Radical Orthodoxy "univocity caused secular modernity" thesis as established history [SOURCE CAUTION]; it is contested.

13. [SOURCE CAUTION] Do not label D. Z. Phillips a non-cognitivist without qualification. He explicitly rejected the label and the charge of reductionism; report the dispute.

15. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not claim that non-literal semantics dissolves all inter-religious conflict. Existence-claims are not mode-relative — route hard contradictions, do not harmonise them.

10. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not describe Scotus' univocity as an ontological claim that God and creatures are beings in the same way. It is semantic: the concept is common, and the finite/infinite intrinsic modes restore the difference.

12. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Do not treat cognitivism/non-cognitivism as two boxes. Use the ten-point spectrum in §9.9 and place each thinker precisely.

14. [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Preserve the Tillich caution. Tillich says the statement "God is being-itself" is the one non-symbolic statement, but he modified this position in later work, and the exception is internally disputed. Never present it as an untroubled doctrine.



13. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

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Keywords: [FACT] univocal/equivocal/analogical · attribution · proportionality · res significata/modus significandi · causal participation · univocity of the concept of being · intrinsic modes (finite/infinite) · certain and doubtful concepts · onto-theology [SOURCE CAUTION] · via negativa · attributes of action (Maimonides) · sign/symbol · participation · being-itself · ultimate concern · the demonic · idolatry · model and qualifier · disclosure situation · performative/constative · illocutionary force · self-involving language · samkalpa (intentional resolve) · vidhi (injunction) (injunctive mood) · śabda-nityatva (eternality of word) · mantra · verification · falsification ·

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eschatological verification · parable of the gardener · thousand qualifications · partisan and Stranger · moral policy · blik · language-game · form of life · non-realism/fictionalism · neti neti (not this, not this) · lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning) · jahad-ajahal-lakṣaṇā (implication by partial abandonment and retention)/bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā (implication by partial rejection and retention) · anirvacanīya (indefinable as either real or unreal) (of māyā (cosmic appearance and creative power)) · pratīka (symbolic aid to meditation)/pratimā (sacred image or icon) · omkāra (sacred syllable Om) and turīya (fourth state of consciousness) · cataphatic/apophatic · second



CONTINUATION 3/3

naïveté · transcategorical Real · personae/impersonae · anekāntavāda (doctrine of many-sided reality)/syādvāda (doctrine of conditioned predication)/saptabhaṅgī (sevenfold predication).

Safe formulations: [INFERENCE / CAUTION] "Religious utterances can be simultaneously assertoric, symbolic and performative." · "The central issue is not only whether God-talk is meaningful, but what mode of meaning fits transcendence." · "Univocity secures inference and risks anthropomorphism; analogy secures transcendence and risks indeterminacy; negation secures purity and risks vacuity." · "How one speaks about God determines how many traditions one can regard as speaking about God."

CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (expanded PYQ audit)

- [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Priority: Primary ownership is 14 of 112 parts, second only to the soul–rebirth–liberation clause.

- [FACT] Required doctrinal depth: Older papers add secular versus religious use, Braithwaite, symbolism leading to mysticism, transcendent-reference mediation, cognitive content and Tillich before the recent analogy/cognitivism cycle.



- ? Trap / answer consequence: Do not merge symbol, analogy and non-cognitivism; distinguish semantic mode from truth-aptness, and a participatory symbol from a conventional sign.

14. PYQ ROUTING (2018–2025)

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

[INFERENCE / CAUTION] Corpus signal: 14 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper II corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

2018	Q5(a)	10 marks	In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use of language? Discuss.
2018	Q7(b)	15 marks	Critically examine Braithwaite's non-cognitive theory of religious language.
2018	Q8(c)	15 marks	Explain the significance of religious symbols as transcendent referent that mediates into the cultural, spatial and temporal world.
2019	Q6(a)	20 marks	Discuss whether and how does religious symbolism lead to mysticism.

2020	Q8(a)	20 marks	Does religious language carry cognitive content? Elucidate in detail.
2021	Q8(a)	20 marks	What is non-cognitive theory of religious language? Explain critically in the light of R. B. Braithwaite's views.
2021	Q8(c)	15 marks	Explain the symbolic nature of religious language with special reference to Paul Tillich.
2022	Q5(e)	10 marks	Explain the difference between the cognitivist and non-cognitivist approaches to the religious language with reference to the statement — "God exists".
2023	Q5(d)	10 marks	Discuss Wittgenstein's view about the non-cognitive nature of religious language.
2023	Q7(c)	15 marks	Explain the symbolic nature of religious language according to Tillich.
2024	Q5(e)	10 marks	Explain the analogical nature of religious language.
2024	Q8(a)	20 marks (10+10)	Distinguish between cognitivist and non-cognitivist account of religious language. Does the cognitivist account lead to any contradiction? Answer with reference to the philosophical views of R. B. Braithwaite.
2025	Q5(b)	10 marks	Is religious language symbolic? Give reasons and justification in support of your answer.
2025	Q8(c)	15 marks	Discuss the Advaitic notion of indescribability (anirvacanīyatā (indefinability as either real or unreal)) in the context of nature of religious language.

See the Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018–2025.

15. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 MARKS)

10 marks

Define theory → mechanism of meaning → canonical example → nearest contrast → one objection → verdict.

15 marks

Frame finite-language problem → doctrine's argument and presupposition → example → critic and reply → Indian/Western comparison.

20 marks

Separate HOW from WHETHER → compare cognitive and non-cognitive families → verification/falsification pressure → analogy/symbol/Advaita (non-dualism) resources → two objections and a mixed, defended conclusion.

16. DIRECTIVE DECODER

In what sense is A different from B?	A specified respect of difference, not a list	Name the axes first (function, referent, logic, commitment)	2018 Q5(a) secular vs religious use
Critically examine [thinker]'s theory	Reconstruction plus evaluation	State the theory in its own terms before objecting	2018 Q7(b) Braithwaite
Explain the significance of X as Y that mediates into...	The mediation mechanism, not just the significance	Participation (Tillich) + hierophany (Eliade)	2018 Q8(c)
Discuss whether and how X leads to Y	Two deliverables; the "how" is the harder one	Route in steps; then give the negative case	2019 Q6(a)
Does X carry cognitive content? Elucidate in detail	A defended position on truth-aptness	Spectrum, not binary; then the verification/falsification pressure	2020 Q8(a)
What is X? Explain critically in the light of [thinker]	Definition, then the thinker's version, then critique	Braithwaite's version ≠ Ayer's ≠ Wittgenstein's	2021 Q8(a)
Explain the difference between A and B with reference to [a specific statement]	The distinction applied to that sentence	Run "God exists" through both accounts explicitly	2022 Q5(e)
Distinguish A and B. Does A lead to any contradiction?	Two parts, with the second answered directly	Name the alleged contradiction, then adjudicate it	2024 Q8(a) (10+10 — obey the split)
Is X symbolic? Give reasons and justification	A yes/no with reasons ranked	Position first; Tillich's criteria; then the caution	2025 Q5(b)
Discuss X in the context of the nature of religious language	The doctrine as a semantic thesis	Anirvacanīyatā (indefinability as either real or unreal) must be presented as a claim about predication	2025 Q8(c)

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

[MNEMONIC] Rule: every question in this clause sits on one of two axes — HOW transcendent predicates signify (univocal / analogical / symbolic / negative / indicative) and WHETHER the utterance is truth-apt (the ten-point spectrum). Say in your opening which axis the question is on; several stems sit on both, and saying so is itself a mark.

17. GRADED VERDICT LADDER

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious language is neither crudely literal nor semantically empty; its strongest account combines qualified cognition, analogy or symbol, self-involvement and apophatic limits.

Weak (≈40%)	"Aquinas said analogy, Tillich said symbol, Ayer said meaningless"	HOW and WHETHER merged; no mechanism given
Average (≈50%)	Analogy's two forms; symbol vs sign; cognitivism vs non-cognitivism	Non-cognitivists lumped together; no Indian material
Good (≈60%)	Mechanism of meaning stated; one objection answered; neti neti (not this, not this)/lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning) used	Spectrum treated as a binary; Scotus absent
Strong (≈65–70%)	Spectrum placed accurately; falsification debate (Flew–Hare–Mitchell); Indian parity argued	Tillich's exception reported without its caution
Top (≈70%+)	All the above + a discriminating distinction (res significata/modus significandi; semantic vs ontological univocity; Brahman (ultimate reality)'s ineffability vs māyā (cosmic appearance and creative power)'s anirvacanīyatā (indefinability as either real or unreal); symbol vs sign vs model-and-qualifier) + the pluralism bridge (§9.10)	—

Graded-verdict templates:

- [INFERENCE / CAUTION] HOW stem: "The predicate applies neither in the creaturely sense nor in no sense at all. What secures the middle position is _ (causal participation / participation-in-being / indirect indication), and its standing cost is indeterminacy — which is exactly what the univocity theorist exploits."



- [INFERENCE / CAUTION] WHETHER stem: "Religious utterances are assertoric, symbolic and performative at once. Non-cognitivism correctly identifies the practical force and incorrectly denies the assertoric intent; the defensible position is a mixed speech-act account with defeasible, non-decisively-falsifiable claims."

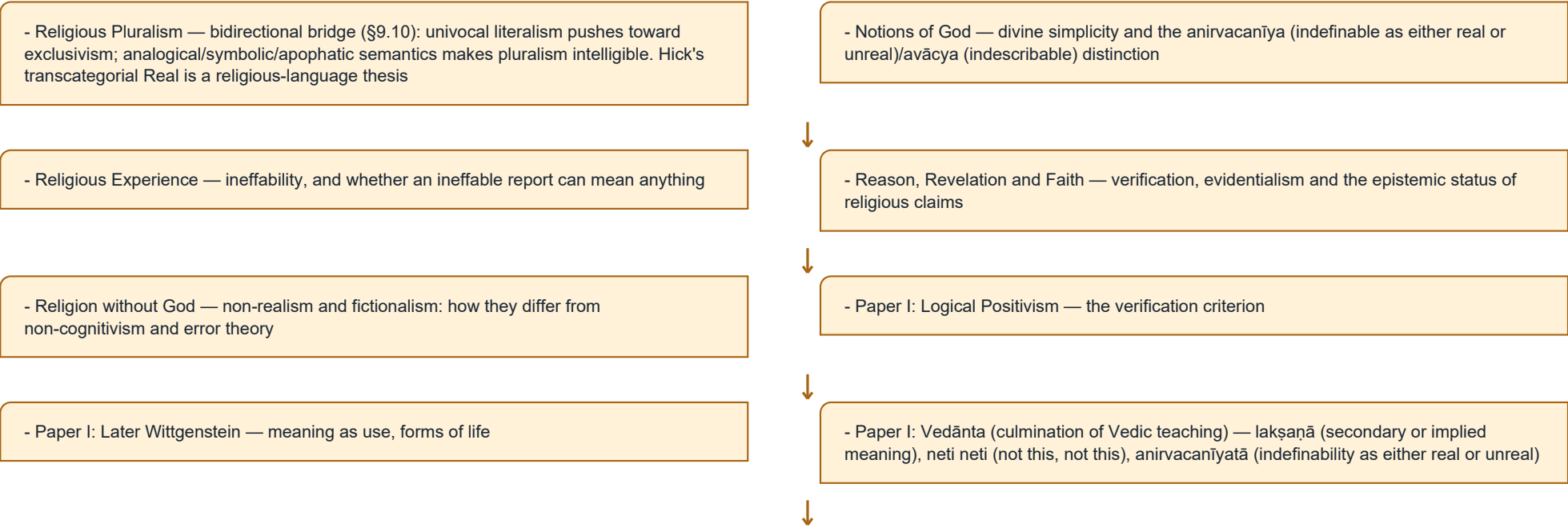
- [INFERENCE / CAUTION] Advaita (non-dualism) stem: "Anirvacanīyatā (indefinability as either real or unreal) is a thesis about predication, not a confession of ignorance: it says the world-appearance cannot be classified as either real or unreal, and that Brahman (ultimate reality) is not an object of objectifying speech. Language then works eliminatively (neti neti (not this, not this)) and indicatively (lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning)) rather than descriptively — and it is sublated once it has done its work."

18. FACTUAL AND QUOTATION DISCIPLINE

Analogy of attribution/proportionality	[FACT] Aquinas, ST I q.13 (the divine names)	Give the res significata/modus significandi pair
"Healthy" example	[FACT] Aquinas' own example of ordered predication	Note it illustrates attribution, not divine goodness directly
Univocity of being	[FACT] Duns Scotus, Ordinatio I d.3	Semantic, not ontological; intrinsic modes finite/infinite
"Univocity produced modern secularity"	[SOURCE CAUTION] Radical Orthodoxy (Milbank, Pickstock) — a contested historical thesis	Cite as contested, never as settled
Negations and attributes of action	[FACT] Maimonides, Guide for the Perplexed I.50–60	The Jewish via negativa
Cataphatic → apophatic ascent	[FACT] Pseudo-Dionysius, Mystical Theology	The classical route from symbol to unknowing
Symbol participates; "God is being-itself" as non-symbolic	[FACT] Tillich, Dynamics of Faith; Systematic Theology	[INFERENCE / CAUTION] Preserve the caution: Tillich modified the exception in later work and its status is disputed
"The symbol gives rise to thought"	[FACT] Paul Ricoeur, The Symbolism of Evil	Also "second naïveté"
Model and qualifier; disclosure situation	[FACT] Ian Ramsey, Religious Language (1957)	Explains how ordinary words are stretched religiously
Constative/performative; illocutionary force	[FACT] J. L. Austin, How to Do Things with Words	Applied to religion by Evans
The Logic of Self-Involvement	[FACT] Donald Evans (1963)	Self-involving religious utterance
Parable of the invisible gardener	[FACT] Antony Flew (adapting John Wisdom), "Theology and Falsification" (1950–51)	"Death by a thousand qualifications"
Blik; the paranoid student	[FACT] R. M. Hare, same symposium	Unfalsifiable but not unimportant
The partisan and the Stranger	[FACT] Basil Mitchell, same symposium	Defeasible trust that concedes counterevidence
Eschatological verification; celestial city	[FACT] John Hick	Truth-apt now, confirmable later
Moral policy + stories	[FACT] R. B. Braithwaite, An Empiricist's View of the Nature of Religious Belief (1955)	"God is love" = an agapeistic intention
Verification criterion	[FACT] A. J. Ayer, Language, Truth and Logic	Hostile non-cognitivism; note the criterion's self-application problem

D. Z. Phillips as a "non-cognitivist"	[SOURCE CAUTION] He explicitly rejected the label and the reductionism charge	Report the dispute; do not assert the label
Transcategorical Real; personae/impersonae	[FACT] John Hick, An Interpretation of Religion	The pluralism bridge is a semantic thesis
Neti neti (not this, not this); yato vāco nivartante (from which words return)	[FACT] Bṛhadāraṇyaka 2.3.6; Taittirīya 2.9	Give the references
Bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā (implication by partial rejection and retention) in "tat tvam asi (That thou art)"	[FACT] Standard Advaita (non-dualism) exegesis of Chāndogya 6.8.7	The Indian analogue of analogy
Anirvacanīya (indefinable as either real or unreal)	[FACT] Technically the status of māyā (cosmic appearance and creative power) (sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa (different from both real and unreal))	Do not use it as a synonym for Brahman (ultimate reality)'s ineffability; standard spelling anirvacanīya (indefinable as either real or unreal)
Om̐kāra (sacred syllable Om) and the soundless fourth	[FACT] Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad (philosophical Vedic text)	Symbol leading beyond itself
Sphoṭa (indivisible burst of linguistic meaning)	[FACT] Grammarian doctrine (Bhartṛhari)	Never attribute to Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school)

19. LINK-OUTS



- Paper I: Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) — vidhi (injunction), śabda-nityatva (eternality of word), the injunctive mood

- Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018–2025

- Paper I: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika — near-univocal predication of Īśvara (Lord or special spiritual self)



SOURCES

- Thomas Aquinas, Summa Theologiae I q.13 (on names said of God); John Duns Scotus, Ordinatio I d.3 (univocity); Moses Maimonides, Guide for the Perplexed I.50–60.

- Paul Tillich, Dynamics of Faith and Systematic Theology; Ian Ramsey, Religious Language.

- A. J. Ayer, Language, Truth and Logic; R. B. Braithwaite, An Empiricist's View of the Nature of Religious Belief; the Flew–Hare–Mitchell symposium "Theology and Falsification"; William Alston, Divine Nature and Human Language.

- Advaita (non-dualism) and Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) discussions in S. Radhakrishnan, S. C. Chatterjee & D. M. Datta, and C. D. Sharma.

- Pseudo-Dionysius, The Mystical Theology; Paul Ricoeur, The Symbolism of Evil.

- J. L. Austin, How to Do Things with Words; Donald Evans, The Logic of Self-Involvement.

- John Hick, Philosophy of Religion and An Interpretation of Religion.



PYQ ROUTES + ANSWER SPINES

FULL MODEL PROSE NOT DUPLICATED

HOW TO READ THESE ROUTES

Route discipline: question → directive/demand → named evidence → objection/reply → bounded verdict. Each card preserves the source-owned demand decoder and its explicit marks-earning criteria.

2018 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

QUESTION: In what sense is the secular use of language different from the religious use of language? Discuss.

DEMAND ROUTE: “In what sense” requires specified axes of difference, not a hunt for a separate sacred vocabulary. “Discuss” requires both discontinuity and continuity. The answer should compare function, reference, verification, logic and self-involvement.

SCORING SPINE: Opens with the decisive “use, not vocabulary” thesis. • Organises comparison through explicit semantic and pragmatic axes. • Uses Austin, Evans and Ramsey as evidence rather than name-dropping. • Adds precise Indian parallels: vidhi (injunction), mantra, neti neti (not this, not that) and lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning). • Preserves the mixed character of religious speech instead of declaring it wholly non-cognitive.

2018 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

QUESTION: Critically examine Braithwaite’s non-cognitive theory of religious language.

DEMAND ROUTE: “Critically examine” requires a fair reconstruction of Braithwaite’s distinct moral-conative account, its argument and examples, followed by strengths, objections, possible reply and a reasoned verdict. It must not be collapsed into Ayer, Hare or Wittgenstein.

SCORING SPINE: Identifies the 1955 text, moral policy, agape and sustaining stories accurately. • Distinguishes Braithwaite from Ayer, Hare and Wittgensteinian approaches. • Connects doctrine to Evans’ self-involvement while preserving conceptual differences. • Tests the view against believer intent and the diversity of religious speech acts. • Ends with a defended mixed-account verdict rather than an unqualified rejection.

**2018 · Q8(c) · 15 marks**

QUESTION: Explain the significance of religious symbols as transcendent referent that mediates into the cultural, spatial and temporal world.

DEMAND ROUTE: The directive asks for the mechanism and significance of mediation: how a symbol relates transcendence to finite cultural, spatial and temporal forms. Tillich’s participation must be central, with examples and a warning against treating symbols as mere signs or literal absolutes.

SCORING SPINE: Explains mediation rather than merely listing the uses of symbols. • Preserves Tillich’s crucial symbol/sign and participation distinctions. • Develops all three demanded dimensions: cultural, spatial and temporal. • Uses Ricoeur and Eliade to show interpretive and spatial mechanisms. • Balances disclosure with idolatry, the demonic and referential-vagueness objections.

2019 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

QUESTION: Discuss whether and how does religious symbolism lead to mysticism.

DEMAND ROUTE: The stem contains two obligations: decide whether symbolism leads to mysticism and explain how the transition occurs. A 20-marker must reconstruct the affirmative route, provide Western and Indian evidence, develop the negative case, and deliver a qualified verdict rather than assuming necessity.

SCORING SPINE: Answers “whether” immediately and gives a four-stage account of “how.” • Uses Tillich’s participation to establish the causal-semantic mechanism. • Integrates Ricoeur, Pseudo-Dionysius, upāsana (meditative worship) and Māṇḍūkya as evidence. • Includes the mandatory negative case: idolatry, Katz, iconoclastic routes and non-necessity. • Distinguishes symbol as route, symbol as arrest and symbol as constitutive framework. • Concludes with a precise conditional verdict rather than a simplistic yes/no.

**2020 · Q8(a) · 20 marks**

QUESTION: Does religious language carry cognitive content? Elucidate in detail.

DEMAND ROUTE: “Does” requires a defended answer; “elucidate in detail” requires a spectrum rather than two boxes. The answer must define cognitive content, examine verification and falsification, compare realist, symbolic, performative and non-cognitive positions, and defend a nuanced conclusion.

SCORING SPINE: Gives a direct, graded thesis and defines the cognitive issue through truth-aptness. • Treats the field as a spectrum, accurately placing Aquinas, Tillich, Hick and mixed accounts. • Reconstructs the Ayer–Flew–Hare–Mitchell debate with named parables. • Uses Braithwaite and Wittgensteinian use without collapsing their positions. • Adds Advaita (non-dualism) while protecting the Brahman (ultimate reality)/anirvacanīyatā (indefinability as either real or unreal) distinction. • Defends a mixed speech-act realism with an explicit evidential qualification.

2021 · Q8(a) · 20 marks

QUESTION: What is non-cognitive theory of religious language? Explain critically in the light of R. B. Braithwaite’s views.

DEMAND ROUTE: Define non-cognitivism, distinguish its variants, then give Braithwaite the main analytical space. “Critically” requires strengths, internal and external objections, comparison, reply and verdict. The answer must not equate “non-cognitive” with insignificant or meaningless.

SCORING SPINE: Defines the non-cognitive family while differentiating its members. • Reconstructs Braithwaite through policy, agape and stories in his own terms. • Uses Austin and Evans to explain, not merely praise, his practical insight. • Develops four distinct criticisms, including believer intent and adjudication. • Compares Hare, Wittgensteinian use, Mitchell and Hick accurately. • Ends with the precise verdict: valuable pragmatics, inadequate total semantics.



2021 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

QUESTION: Explain the symbolic nature of religious language with special reference to Paul Tillich.

DEMAND ROUTE: Explain Tillich's theory, not symbolism generally. Define symbol against sign; present participation, disclosure, collective origin, growth and death; relate God to being-itself; then assess idolatry, referential vagueness and the disputed non-symbolic exception.

SCORING SPINE: Defines symbol by Tillich's criteria and explicitly distinguishes it from sign. • Connects participation to disclosure and transformation. • Accurately states being-itself, idolatry and the demonic. • Preserves the disputed status of Tillich's non-symbolic exception. • Uses Aquinas as a discriminating contrast and reaches a qualified verdict.

2022 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

QUESTION: Explain the difference between the cognitivist and non-cognitivist approaches to the religious language with reference to the statement — "God exists".

DEMAND ROUTE: Define both approaches and apply each directly to the specified sentence. Comparison must cover truth-aptness, evidence, function and believer intention, ending with a reasoned position rather than an abstract catalogue.

SCORING SPINE: Applies every distinction to the exact sentence in the stem. • Separates the WHETHER axis from modes such as analogy and symbol. • Differentiates Ayer, Braithwaite, Hare and Wittgensteinian use. • Uses Hick and Flew to frame evidence pressure on cognitivism. • Defends a clear mixed-account conclusion.

**2023 · Q5(d) · 10 marks**

QUESTION: Discuss Wittgenstein's view about the non-cognitive nature of religious language.

DEMAND ROUTE: Present the Wittgensteinian use/form-of-life approach, illustrate it, explain why it is often read non-cognitively, and critically qualify that attribution—especially the D. Z. Phillips caution.

SCORING SPINE: Explains language-game, grammar, form of life and meaning-as-use. • Uses the Last Judgement to show how religious use differs from prediction. • Avoids attributing a crude systematic non-cognitivism to Wittgenstein. • Includes the required Phillips qualification and fideism objection. • Gives a balanced verdict with Mitchell as a focused corrective.

2023 · Q7(c) · 15 marks

QUESTION: Explain the symbolic nature of religious language according to Tillich.

DEMAND ROUTE: This repeats the Tillich core but merits a full 15-mark independent model: mechanism, criteria, ontology, strengths, objections and verdict. It should not merely reproduce a definition or call symbols signs.

SCORING SPINE: Reconstructs all major Tillichian criteria of a symbol. • Makes participation—not resemblance—the mechanism of meaning. • Explains being-itself, ultimate concern, idolatry and the demonic. • Handles the non-symbolic exception as disputed rather than settled. • Uses Aquinas to clarify both the theory's achievement and its risk.

**2024 · Q5(e) · 10 marks**

QUESTION: Explain the analogical nature of religious language.

DEMAND ROUTE: Explain why analogy is needed, its two forms, metaphysical basis and technical distinction, then contrast it with Scotus and negation. A 10-marker needs mechanism, example, objection and verdict.

SCORING SPINE: Frames the univocal/equivocal dilemma before presenting the solution. • Explains attribution and proportionality with the "healthy" example correctly limited. • Uses res significata/modus significandi and causal participation. • States Scotus' univocity as semantic, not ontological. • Ends with the exact trade-off between inference, transcendence and indeterminacy.

2024 · Q8(a) · 20 marks (10+10)

QUESTION: Distinguish between cognitivist and non-cognitivist account of religious language. Does the cognitivist account lead to any contradiction? Answer with reference to the philosophical views of R. B. Braithwaite.

DEMAND ROUTE: Respect the printed 10+10 split. Part I must distinguish the two accounts with Braithwaite accurately located. Part II must identify the alleged contradiction/meaning problem confronting cognitivism, assess whether it is genuine, and evaluate Braithwaite's solution. Neither part should swallow the other.

SCORING SPINE: Visibly and substantively obeys the 10+10 allocation. • Distinguishes a spectrum of non-cognitivism rather than merging them. • Locates the alleged contradiction in truth-claim plus evidential immunity. • Explains how Braithwaite escapes the problem and what that escape costs. • Uses Aquinas, Mitchell and Hick as distinct replies to the contradiction claim. • Gives a direct verdict: contradiction is conditional, not inherent.



2025 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

QUESTION: Is religious language symbolic? Give reasons and justification in support of your answer.

DEMAND ROUTE: Take a clear yes/no position, rank reasons, justify through Tillich's criteria and assess limits. The answer must state that symbolic does not mean merely conventional, non-cognitive or wholly devoid of reference.

SCORING SPINE: Answers "yes, but" immediately and then ranks three reasons. • Protects the symbol/sign and participation distinctions. • Uses Om (sacred syllable Om)—turiya (fourth state of consciousness) as evidence for self-transcending symbolism. • Preserves Tillich's being-itself caution and disputed exception. • Qualifies symbolism through mixed speech acts and hard contradictions.

2025 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

QUESTION: Discuss the Advaitic notion of indescribability (anirvacanīyatā (indefinability as either real or unreal)) in the context of nature of religious language.

DEMAND ROUTE: Treat anirvacanīyatā (indefinability as either real or unreal) as a semantic-predicative issue, while preserving the exact distinction: technically it characterises māyā (cosmic appearance and creative power)/world-appearance as neither real nor unreal; Brahman (ultimate reality) is ineffable/non-objectifiable but is not indeterminable in that same ontological sense. Explain neti neti (not this, not this), lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning), self-reference and sublation.

SCORING SPINE: Begins with and sustains the decisive Brahman (ultimate reality)/māyā (cosmic appearance and creative power) distinction. • Defines anirvacanīya (indefinable as either real or unreal) through sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa (different from both real and unreal), not vague ineffability. • Explains neti neti (not this, not this) and lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning) as different semantic operations. • Uses tat tvam asi (That thou art) and bhāga-tyāga-lakṣaṇā (implication by partial rejection and retention) precisely. • Addresses self-reference through the thorn/sublation reply. • Adds focused comparisons with Maimonides and Aquinas before a graded verdict.

**Original 1 · 10 marks**

QUESTION: "Analogy protects transcendence only by sacrificing intelligibility." Examine with reference to Aquinas and Scotus.

DEMAND ROUTE: "Examine" requires testing the claim, not merely defining analogy. Explain Aquinas' mechanism, present Scotus' strongest objection, give the Thomist reply and reach a graded verdict.

SCORING SPINE: Converts the quotation into a precise intelligibility-versus-transcendence problem. • Uses both forms of analogy and the technical signification distinction. • Gives Scotus' certain/doubtful argument and semantic qualification. • Presents the Thomist reply before judging it. • Concludes with a graded, defensible synthesis.

Original 2 · 10 marks

QUESTION: Can religious utterances be performative without ceasing to be cognitive? Discuss.

DEMAND ROUTE: Define performative and cognitive, use concrete religious speech acts, reject the false either/or, and state conditions under which assertion and self-involvement coexist.

SCORING SPINE: Separates semantic truth-aptness from illocutionary force. • Uses Austin, Evans, Braithwaite and Mitchell for distinct analytical jobs. • Supplies varied examples rather than treating all religious speech alike. • Includes Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) vidhi (injunction) as an accurate Indian application. • Gives a direct yes-with-conditions verdict.

**Original 3 · 15 marks**

QUESTION: Compare the via negativa of Maimonides with Advaita (non-dualism)'s neti neti (not this, not this). Do they end in meaningful discourse or silence?

DEMAND ROUTE: Compare grounds, methods and permissible positive speech; include Maimonides' attributes of action and Advaita (non-dualism)'s lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning). "Do they" demands an evaluated conclusion about meaningfulness, self-reference and silence.

SCORING SPINE: Compares metaphysical grounds rather than merely noting shared negation. • Uses Maimonides' negations and attributes of action precisely. • Adds Advaita (non-dualism)'s lakṣaṇā (secondary or implied meaning), sublation and soteriological purpose. • Protects the Brahman (ultimate reality)/māyā (cosmic appearance and creative power) and ineffability/anirvacanīyatā (indefinability as either real or unreal) distinctions. • Addresses both vacuity and self-reference before a graded verdict.

Original 4 · 15 marks

QUESTION: "The meaning of religious language is exhausted neither by truth-conditions nor by use." Critically discuss.

DEMAND ROUTE: Test a synthetic claim. Reconstruct what truth-condition approaches and use theories each explain, show what each misses, compare major thinkers without homogenising them, and defend or reject a mixed account.

SCORING SPINE: Builds the answer around the exact "neither/nor" proposition. • Uses Aquinas, Hick and Mitchell to differentiate cognitive realism. • Uses Austin, Evans, Ramsey and Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school) to analyse practical force. • Preserves Phillips' caution and distinguishes Braithwaite, Hare and Ayer. • Imposes evidential and referential safeguards on the mixed conclusion.

Original 5 · 20 marks

QUESTION: Evaluate the proposition that theories of religious language determine the possibility and limits of religious pluralism.

DEMAND ROUTE: “Evaluate” requires showing the semantic-to-pluralism mechanism, comparing literal, analogical, symbolic and apophatic routes, using Hick and Indian resources, identifying conflicts that semantics cannot dissolve, and issuing a balanced verdict.

SCORING SPINE: States and follows the full semantics-to-pluralism causal chain. • Evaluates univocity, analogy, symbol and negation through their trade-offs. • Shows why Hick’s pluralism is itself a theory of predication. • Uses Advaita (non-dualism) and Jain standpoint logic as distinct, non-decorative resources. • Separates mode-relative descriptions from hard existence-claims. • Qualifies linguistic determination through evidence, ethics and history.

Original 6 · 20 marks

QUESTION: “Religious language is neither literal description nor disguised silence.” Critically assess this claim through analogy, symbol, negation and non-cognitive theories.

DEMAND ROUTE: Organise the answer across the HOW and WHETHER axes. Explain how analogy, symbol and negation seek a middle position; compare cognitive and non-cognitive theories; test anthropomorphism, indeterminacy, vacuity and reductionism; defend a final account.

SCORING SPINE: Structures the entire assessment through the HOW/WHETHER distinction. • Reconstructs analogy, symbol and negation with their exact mechanisms. • Uses Scotus, Maimonides and Advaita (non-dualism) to test semantic continuity and limits. • Differentiates Ayer, Flew, Hare, Mitchell, Hick, Braithwaite and Wittgensteinian use. • Integrates Austin/Evans without inferring that performance cancels cognition. • Ends with three explicit conditions for a defended middle position.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

FINAL RAPID-RETRIEVAL FLOW

A. Two-axis control

HOW	By what semantic mode does God-talk signify?	univocal, analogy, symbol, negation, indication
WHETHER	Is the utterance truth-apt?	cognitive, mixed, non-cognitive, meaningless

B. Univocal, equivocal and analogical

- Univocal sameness risks anthropomorphism.

- Attribution orders secondary use to a source; proportionality compares relations according to mode.

- Total equivocity risks meaninglessness and invalid inference.

- Aquinas uses ordered analogy through causal participation.

C. Aquinas and Scotus

- Res significata: the perfection signified applies truly to God.

- His univocity is semantic, while finite/infinite intrinsic modes preserve ontological difference.

- Modus significandi: the creaturely mode does not.

- Scotus requires a univocal concept for valid inference.

D. Symbol

- A Tillichian symbol participates in what it indicates and opens levels of reality and self.

- Tillich's proposed non-symbolic exception is contested and later qualified.

- "God" points to being-itself, not one being.

- Literalising the finite bearer produces idolatry or the demonic.

E. Negation and indication

- Maimonides allows negations and attributes of action.

- Negation protects transcendence but risks vacuity.

- Advaita (non-dualism) uses *neti neti* (not this, not this) to remove limiting predicates.

- *Lakṣaṇā* (secondary or implied meaning) indirectly indicates what literal denotation cannot.

F. Cognitive spectrum

- Literal and analogical realism remain truth-apt.

- Braithwaite, Hare and Ayer are distinct non-cognitive positions.

- Symbolic realism preserves truth through participatory reference.

- Mixed speech-act views combine assertion, commitment and expression.

G. Verification and falsification

- Ayer demands verification and excludes metaphysics.

- Mitchell permits trust that acknowledges counterevidence.

- Flew asks what could count against qualified God-talk.

- Hick proposes possible eschatological verification.

- Hare's *blik* is unfalsifiable but life-shaping.

H. Use and self-involvement

- Wittgensteinian approaches locate meaning in language-games and forms of life.

- Evans shows that vows, confession and worship involve the speaker.

- D. Z. Phillips rejected a simple non-cognitivist label.

- Austin distinguishes constative and performative force.

I. Secular and religious use

- The difference concerns function, referent, verification, logic and commitment, not vocabulary.

- Ramsey's model-and-qualifier stretches ordinary words in disclosure.

- *Mīmāṃsā* (ritual-exegesis school)'s *vidhi* (injunction) and *mantra* are injunctive or instrumental.

- Śabda-nityatva (eternality of word) is Mīmāṃsā (ritual-exegesis school); sphoṭa (indivisible burst of linguistic meaning) belongs to grammarians.

J. Symbol and mysticism

- Symbol can draw the participant from mediation toward immediacy.

- Symbols can also arrest through literalism; Katz argues they may constitute, not precede, experience.

- Cataphatic language may culminate in apophatic silence.

- Oṃkāra (sacred syllable Om) can lead from sound to turīya (fourth state of consciousness).

K. Advaita (non-dualism) and pluralism bridges

- Brahman (ultimate reality) is beyond objectifying speech; māyā (cosmic appearance and creative power) is anirvacanīya (indefinable as either real or unreal) as neither real nor unreal.

- It cannot dissolve hard existence-contradictions.

- Language works eliminatively and indicatively, then is sublated.

- Non-literal semantics can support pluralism by limiting exhaustive formulation.

L. Final answer discipline

1. Name the axis.

4. Give the nearest rival.

7. Add exact Indian parity where useful.

2. State the finite-language problem.

5. State one canonical example.

8. Give a mixed, bounded verdict.

3. Explain the mechanism, not just the label.

6. Present the strongest objection and reply.

KEY VERDICT / MNEMONIC

Final judgement: Religious language is neither crudely literal nor semantically empty. Its strongest account is analogical or symbolic realism within a mixed speech-act framework, disciplined by evidential vulnerability and apophatic limits.

LAST-MINUTE ANSWER CHECK

Final check before writing: definition controlled; rival positions distinguished; named thinkers/traditions used accurately; strongest objection faced; reply cost admitted; PYQ directive obeyed; conclusion bounded.